

CAR CULTURE

Report: A Third of Americans Can't Rely On Cars — And 16 Million Have No Access At All

So why do we plan our cities like everyone can and does get behind the wheel every day?

**By Kea Wilson**

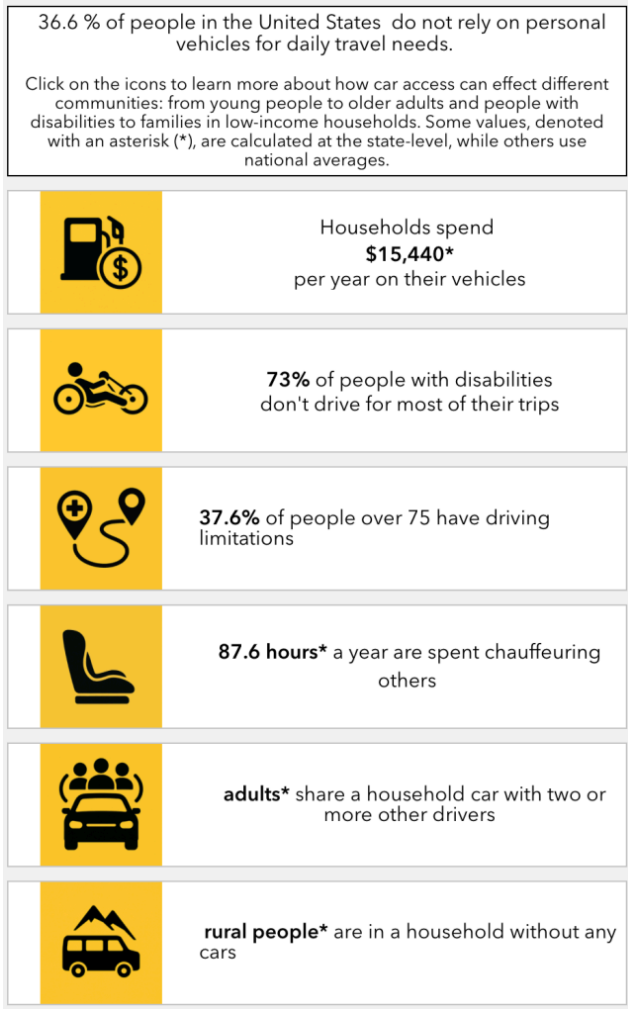
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More than one-third of Americans can't legally or physically drive, belong to households that can't afford a car, or otherwise can't rely on a personal vehicle to meet their daily travel needs, a new report finds — and that means millions of people are being left behind due to car-centric policies.

In what may be the first detailed analysis to systematically count the number of people who aren't served by autocentric development in the United States, analysts at the Natural Resources Defense Council found that roughly 16 million U.S. residents belong to households that have no access to personal vehicles at all — a number that represents one in twenty people.



That astonishing number, though, is just the tip of the iceberg. The researchers estimate that nearly *104* million U.S. residents can't reliably use a personal automobile to get around, including many people with disabilities and people living in poverty — as well as tweens, younger teens, and many elders who *should* be capable of navigating their cities independently, but can't always safely or legally get behind the wheel.

Altogether, that represents a staggering 36 percent of the U.S. population; only 25 percent of total transportation infrastructure spending, meanwhile, flows towards transit, biking, and walking.

Worse, because the federal government doesn't bother to count non-drivers — and state and local governments generally don't either — multimodal advocates are often told that *everyone* drives in their community, so there's little point in supporting those that don't.

"We often hear advocates asking how many people don't drive in their jurisdictions when trying to engage with their policymakers," said Ali Lehman, the

NRDC’s mobility choices research associate and the co-author of the study. “Personally, I think this is a big opportunity to correct [the myth] that people who don’t drive are [living] some sort of fringe lifestyle — that not having access to a car is something that only hippies do, or people who are obsessed with biking. Because as the report details, there’s a lot of nuance [here.]”

For Lehman, those nuances paint a sobering portrait of just how misaligned America’s transportation policies are with the realities of how people actually move through their communities.

During her analysis, Lehman found that a shocking 34.6 million U.S. adults — or about 12.6 percent of the entire U.S. population — either have disabilities that physically prevent them from driving, like vision impairments or neurological disorders like dementia, or belong to a household that doesn’t have a car for some *other* reason, like not being able to afford one.

Table 1: POPULATIONS DEPENDENT ON NON-AUTO MODES

Total nondrivers: 103,998,856
Percent of population: 36%

Description	Percent of population	Assumption	Total people dependent on non-auto modes
Total population over 10		Reference number from U.S. Census	289,483,529
People of driving age who are in households where there are 2 or more drivers than vehicles	9%	Base estimate from Census. May include people who are not drivers but meet the adult-to-vehicle ratio parameters.	26,092,093
People with disabilities (18+) who either don't drive or don't have car access	12.6%	Estimate using CDC's Places and the Federal Highway Administration's National Household Travel Survey	34,633,696
People who are 75+ in a car household with constraints on their driving but without a "travel-limiting" disability	2%	Estimate using data from the National Household Travel Survey	5,835,991
Young people (ages 10-15)	7.5%	Census-based estimate. Includes people under legal driving age but with independent travel needs and abilities	21,673,860
People who are 16+ in a household without a car	5.4%	Census-based estimate of adults living in households with no vehicles	15,763,217

NRDC

Of the one in four Americans who self-identify as having a

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disability, 24.9 percent of adults under 65 live in poverty; retrofitting a van to be wheelchair accessible and operable with hand controls, meanwhile, can cost more than \$30,000, while other types of vehicle modifications may cost even more.

“[A lot of times], people will push for car infrastructure [by saying] that cars are necessary for people with disabilities,” Lehman adds. “And that is probably true

for a lot of people — but there are also a lot of people who can't drive *because* of their disabilities.”

Another 5.8 million Americans — or fully 2 percent of the population — identified as seniors over 75 *without* disabilities, who say they can still drive *sometimes*, but might, for instance, struggle to see after dark. That leaves countless seniors essentially housebound at night unless they can catch a ride with someone else, or have the good fortune to live in a neighborhood that makes other modes convenient.

And then there are the kids, whose mobility needs are rarely discussed by transportation officials who assume that all caregivers can double as private chauffeurs. The researchers found that 21.6 million U.S. residents, or 7.5 percent of the population, fall into the age range of 10 to 15, when they're too young to legally drive in most states but theoretically old enough to walk or bike to school and other destinations alone — or they would be, if their communities were safer.

A map of the concentration of non-drivers by U.S. congressional district. Visit [NRDC](#) to look up yours.

Even adding up all those people, though, is still likely an undercount of the “non-driver movement”, to quote a term coined by disability activist and Week Without Driving co-founder Anna Zivarts. (In her own back-of-the-envelope calculation, Zivarts estimated that 30 percent of Americans couldn't drive, but acknowledged that this number probably didn't paint a full picture.)

For instance, the NRDC researchers weren't able to include people who have lost their licenses due to criminal convictions, or who couldn't get one in the first

place because of their immigration status. People who are temporarily disabled because of things like injury, illness, or medical treatments that make driving unsafe also aren't included, even if those temporary disabilities last for years.

None of that, by the way, counts the people who don't drive by choice, even if they technically have a car in the garage that they reported to the National Household Travel Survey, from which the researchers pulled much of their data. And if all those non-drivers are invisible to researchers on the hunt for non-drivers, that means they're even more invisible to policymakers and transportation officials, who are shaping our transportation decisions around the belief that virtually all of their constituents have easy access to a car.

"The assumption that everyone drives [underlies] how our system has been built out," said Samantha Henningson, NRDC's senior transportation advocate at the co-author of the report. "I think that's just a cultural norm — and also, a norm of how our transportation dollars get spent."



Of course, both Henningson and Lehman stress that being car-free isn't *always* a burden. In their dashboard, overlaid transit maps reveal that many non-driving hotspots like Manhattan (above) are rich in other mobility options that can make life without a car safer, healthier, more affordable and more connected than life with one.

But both researchers caution against assuming that *all* communities with high concentrations of non-drivers are rich in transit options.

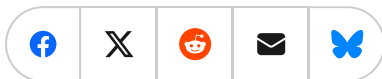
For instance, roughly 40 percent of residents of Ohio's 14th district — which contains the city of Cleveland — live in a household with fewer cars than people, ranking them among the districts where residents are least likely to have personal vehicles in the U.S. Only 10.5 percent of residents of Cleveland proper ride the city's transit network, which runs infrequently relative to many larger cities, and whose routes thin out significantly outside of the downtown core.

Of course, the researchers weren't able to determine why, exactly, cities like Cleveland have so many non-drivers — and they acknowledge that sometimes the answer isn't simple. One person who forgoes car ownership might have a disability *and* ethical objections to contributing to climate change every time they fill up a gas tank; another might *want* to buy a convertible the minute they can afford one because they're a car enthusiast, even if there's a great bus line running right outside their door.

Regardless of why Americans are non-drivers, though, Henningson says policymakers need to acknowledge that non-drivers still exist in massive numbers, despite a century of building a transportation system that pushes hundreds of millions of people towards car ownership — and they always will, if for no other reason than because cities cannot geometrically accommodate every single adult and child driving (or being driven in) a personal automobile.

And as Congress gears up to pass the next federal transportation package in 2026, they must take action to give non-drivers more and better mobility options — and not to be surprised how quickly their ranks grow when they do.

“Transportation has been politicized in a way now that it hasn’t been previously,” she adds. “With the surface transportation reauthorization upcoming, we need to give policymakers tools look at these groups who are overlooked in planning decisions.”



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Kea Wilson is Senior Editor for Streetsblog USA. She has more than a dozen years experience as a writer telling emotional, urgent and actionable stories that motivate average Americans to get involved in making their cities better places. She is also a novelist, cyclist, and affordable housing advocate. She lives in St. Louis, MO. For tips, submissions, and general questions, reach out to her at kea@streetsblog.org, or on Bluesky [@keawilson.bsky.social](https://bsky.app/profile/keawilson.bsky.social).

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